

QED SHANKKAR AIYAR

Can Kashmir Afford Azadi?



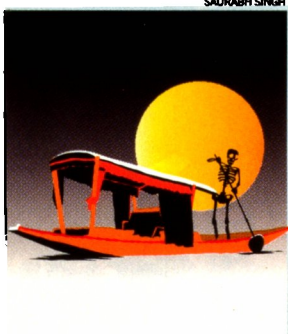
The stench of rotten politics is wafting down the Kashmir Valley but the nausea has gripped the whole nation. Defiance without logic is the reigning dialect and stridency bordering on lunacy the calling card. Sloganeering has replaced dialogue, the Valley's leaders have been found to be duplicitous and the King called Singh has no new ideas. Typically of the UPA, everyone has someone to blame but nobody is responsible.

A decade of hard work has been reversed in hours in the quest for votes. It is as if time has stood still. Lone, Mirwaiz, Abdullah, Mufti are still the names that ring in the Valley but the face of the rebellion is the new generation. Tragically, even they choose to articulate in the old language of separatism. The failed state of Pakistan is yet deemed a "friend".

Last week Kashmiris mindlessly marched again calling for azadi. It was as if the arithmetic of economics didn't apply to Kashmir. As if someone will always pick up their bills. In October 2002, INDIA TODAY computed that in 12 years between 1990 and 2002, Jammu and

Kashmir got Rs 35,571 crore in grants assistance. I revisited the numbers. Grants from the Centre doubled to touch Rs 38,156 crore in five years between 2003 and 2008. The extent of pampering is revealing. In 2007-08 the contributed a princely sum of Rs 533 crore as direct taxes to the Centre and received Rs 1,471 crore from the Central tax kitty and Rs 8,962 crore in grants. Its own revenue of Rs 2,299 crore will not cover the salary bill of Rs 4,389 crore. Even without Jammu and Ladakh, azadi unsustainable. To sum up, of Rs 16,267 crore spent last year, two-thirds or 65 paise out of every rupee came from the Centre. This year the state will spend Rs 17,354 crore of which Rs 11,510 crore or Rs 11,510 per person will come from the Centre. Compare this with the Rs 700 per capita that Uttar Pradesh gets. Worse, Uttar Pradesh will 70 per cent of the grant while Jammu & Kashmir only 10 per cent.

You could ask where has all this money gone? But that is not the question separatists want to ask either the PDP or National Conference. That would mean looking first for the enemy within. Azadi sounds more romantic and many across the border will revel in the rebellion. But those chanting and echoing slogans in the Valley need to wake up to one critical question: Can they afford the delusion of azadi?



SAURABH SINGH



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

Winds of Change

DELHI Finally, the youth wings of the Congress will get to elect their office bearers, including the presidents of both the Indian Youth Congress (IYC) and the National Students Union of India (NSUI). But this is where democracy stops—the elections will be limited to the youth wings and will not include the parent party. In other words, nomination rather than election still remains the norm for the Congress Working Committee and the Pradesh Congress Committee chiefs. But it's a beginning of change.

Ever since Rahul Gandhi took over as the general secretary in-charge of the two wings, he has been pushing for a more open and democratic process. At his behest, the party's membership drive was made more transparent and forms were put online. This indicates an end to the culture of groupies with each leader bringing his cronies and controlling the membership drive.

The same crony cul-

ture applied to the post of the IYC chief as senior leaders tried to control the organisation by promoting their nominees. The only time an election was held for the post of the IYC president was in 1971 when Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi was elected. Since then, all 13 presidents were nominated. NSUI polls will be held in Uttaranchal followed by elections for the IYC posts in Punjab. As a youth worker joked, if polls can be held in faction-ridden Punjab, they can be held anywhere.

These plans were unveiled to rest of the general secretaries at a presentation at the party office. Also on the cards is a plan to introduce an 'aam admi ka sipahi' (soldier for the common man) at the panchayat levels to act as a bridge between the Government and the public. An added flavour to the slick presentation was that Treasurer Motilal Vohra loosened the purse strings for the meeting so that the leaders got enough food for thought that evening. **by Priya Sahgal**